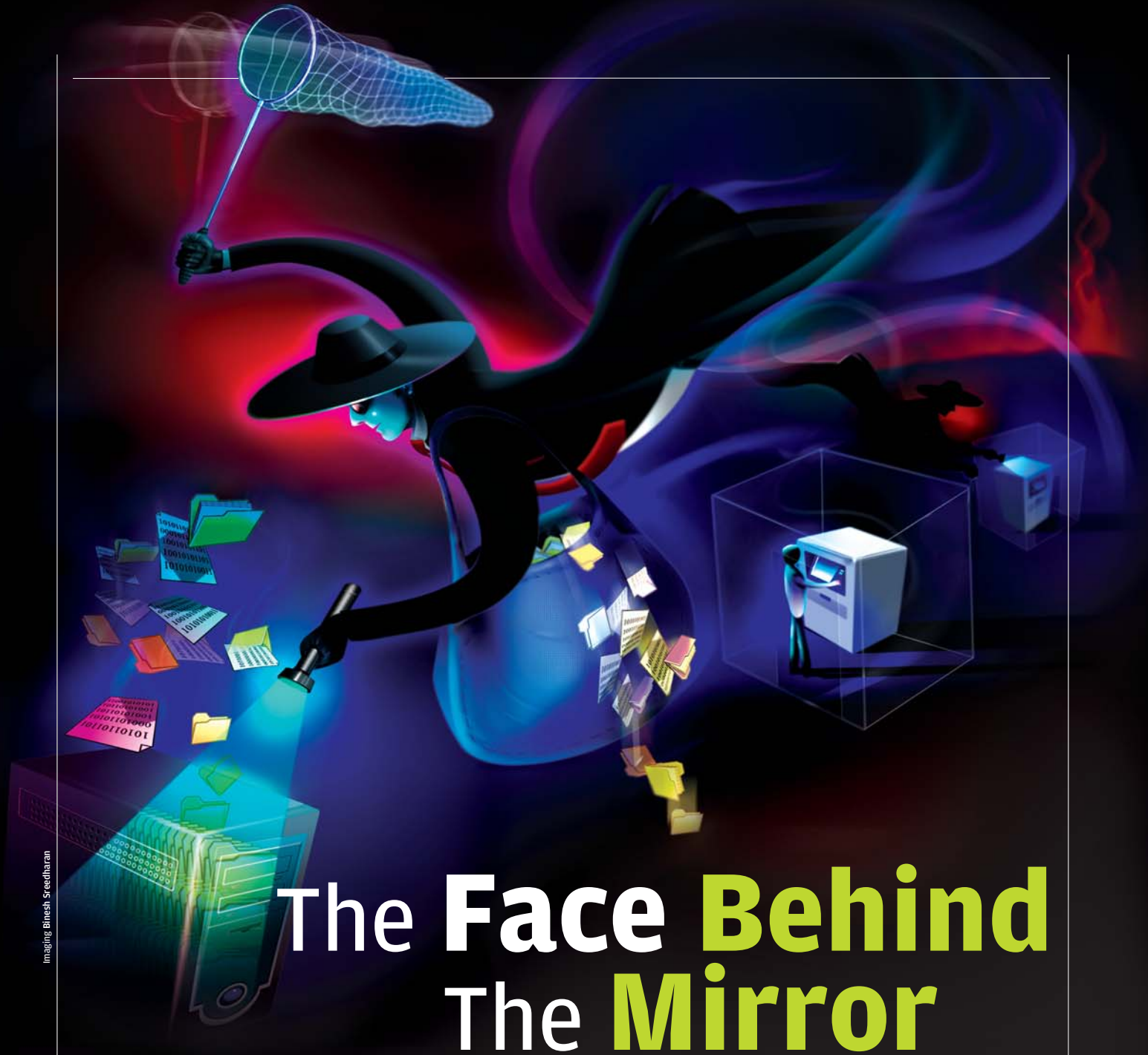




Imaging Bireesh Sreedharan

The Face Behind The Mirror

The fastest-growing crime in the US, ID theft, is a real threat in India too with the growing reach of technology

Ram Mohan Rao

Who are you? In the ages past, you were what people knew you as; what your friends knew you to be; what your customers expected from you. In this digital age, you are merely data.

Your e-mail ID is more relevant to this connected world than your birth name. Today, your Web site's URL brings you more business and recognition than any other avenue. How many friends do you have online—virtual personalities you haven't even met—as against those offline? Social interactions too, are fast taking a digital role. That we are living in a connected world is such a truism that the statement holds no value and will soon be as useful as stating that the world is round.

When data thus defines your wealth, shapes your standing in society, becomes your ego and ID, it gains value. If you happen to have a desirable identity—a bank account number with a sizeable balance, for example—that identity invariably attracts thieves.

What if you were to wake up tomorrow and find out that you have been leading a double life; that someone out there has been your virtual Mr Hyde misappropriating your money, using your credit card number to commit fraud, abusing your online portfolio? How would you feel to learn that your hard-earned cash and reputation has been virtually sold and abused? Unlikely to happen, you say? Identity theft is scary because it is easy. Even you can do it... with a little patience and the right bent of mind. It is a low-risk, high-gain and low-penalty crime.